

NOT QUITE A DISASTER AFTER ALL
by Buku Sarkar
HARPERCOLLINS
₹499; 202 pages

trawling New York's gutters in the company of people for whom dealing and using drugs is as commonplace as eating mishti doi in Calcutta. She's sustained by handouts from Daddy, as well as by the rare flicker of affection from the barely-sentient Shane. As a piece of documentary, it's vivid. But the hand holding the camera is the same one that withheld a Coke from her young cousin. Perhaps. We don't know for sure.

These are powerful stories. They make you think. And look away. ■

Manjula Padmanabhan

rate of interest than shady businessmen. This scene, which could've finished as a satisfactory beat-down, instead chose to swing for the fences. It's miraculously good, as are many of the other scenes. A chance meeting by night aboard a local train segues into a touching section about parents and children, a conversation about forging documents offers insights on conversion and religious duty.

These sleights of hand are possible because Solanki understands the dynamics of noir—for example, in the bit about conversion and forged documents, he is confident enough to slip in a joke about a former pope. Manjhi's forger, Martin Kalu, has only one line he won't cross; because of his faith, he won't create 'fake Christian' documents. Manjhi asks him once again to "make him a John or a Paul".

Manjhi's Mayhem is a thrilling, action-packed, cerebral novel—hopefully, the first of many featuring Sewaram Manjhi. ■

Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS

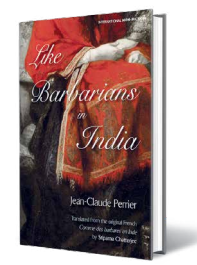
League of Extraordinary Indophiles



***Jean-Claude Perrier**'s breathless homage to India and the French travellers who have loved it*

India evokes strong emotions in those who fall into its warm embrace. Love it or loathe it, you can't ignore it. Jean-Claude Perrier's *Like Barbarians in India* revolves around four French writers—Pierre Loti, Henri Michaux, André Malraux and André Gide—who wrote (mostly) endearingly about India. Of them, only Gide never travelled here.

While Pierre Loti (Captain Julien Viaud in real life) is unapologetically Orientalist ("The people we meet are all beautiful, calm, noble, with big velvet eyes—those Indian eyes with a mysterious black charm") in his *L'Inde: sans les Anglais* ('India without the English'), 1903, with Henri Michaux—half of whose *Un barbare en Asie* ('A Barbarian in Asia'), 1933, is dedicated to India and has inspired this book's title—we are slightly less wide-eyed, but only slightly ("When I saw India... for the first time, people on this earth seemed to me to deserve to be real"). Much more engaged is André Malraux in *Antimémoires* ('Anti-Memoirs'), 1967. He made numerous visits to India and was close to Nehru. As for Gide—who once said, "I am quite resistant to India; its dizzying quality has an opposite effect on me"—his translations of Tagore's works sparked a correspondence with the poet and an interest in Indian literature. Perrier loves them all.



LIKE BARBARIANS IN INDIA
by Jean-Claude Perrier
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹450; 152 pages

Until this book, Perrier himself had 'hardly dared to write about India', apart from a volume with journal entries from a trip through former French colonial posts in India (*Dans les Comptoirs de l'Inde: Carnets de Voyage*, 2003). His literary musings in *Barbarians* are interspersed with his own travels in India. Occasionally, he follows in the writers' footsteps, his path littered with epiphanies. In Mahé, he meets the Sishupals. The wife, Karthy Sishupal, had met Malraux in France, written a dissertation on him and corresponded with him later. She shares a letter from Malraux that Perrier goes on to publish. Rummaging through the Gide archives, he stumbles upon an unpublished translation of Kabir's poems. He writes about a friendship with Pt. Ravi Shankar (they were introduced by Pramod Kapoor of Roli Books).

For a literary history wrapped in a travelogue, this is a remarkably slim and supple book—and introspective. Perrier leaves us with this thought: "But my India, is it the 'real' one? Or am I not tempted by a form of idealisation? Maya, an illusion?". ■

Amit Dixit